



UGANDA NATIONAL INSTITUTE FOR TEACHER EDUCATION
Plot No. 6990 Kitikifumba, Kira Municipality, P.O. Box 7112, Kampala - Uganda.
Telephone: **0414675141**(General) Email: info@unite.ac.ug Website:
www.unite.ac.ug

Office of The Academic Registrar

DEPARTMENT OF EARLY CHILDHOOD EDUCATION

BACHOLERS IN PRE-PRIMARY EDUCATION

COURSE UNIT: INTRODUCTION TO ECE IN EARLY YEARS

COURSE CODE: BEE 1104

STUDENT: LENIA PEACE

REG. NUMBER:

YEAR: ONE

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Coursework Title:

**"The Holistic Educator: From Theory and Policy to Practice,
and Professionalism in the Early Years"**

INDIVIDUAL WRITTEN COURSEWORK

Document Analysis of the NCDC Learning Framework and the EYFS Framework

1. Introduction

The National Curriculum Development Centre (NCDC) Early Learning Framework (Uganda) and the Early Years Foundation Stage (EYFS) Framework (United Kingdom) are both policy documents designed to guide early childhood education. Although they are shaped by different cultural, political, and socio-economic contexts, both share a commitment to promoting holistic child development, high-quality learning experiences, and safeguarding.

This analysis compares the two documents across four thematic areas:

1. Overarching principles, aims, and objectives
2. Learning and development requirements
3. Assessment
4. Safeguarding, welfare, and compliance requirements

The goal is to highlight similarities, differences, and implications for practice in an early childhood setting.

2. Comparison of Overarching Principles (Aims and Objectives)

NCDC Learning Framework

The NCDC framework is centred on holistic development and competency-based learning. Core principles include:

Child-centred and activity-based learning

Emphasis on socio-emotional, physical, cognitive, moral, and language development

Culturally relevant learning materials and local contextualisation

Inclusive education for all children

Learning through play and exploration

Strengthening school–community linkages

The NCDC conceptualises the child as an active participant and emphasises that learning should be experiential, practical, and rooted in Ugandan culture and community values.

EYFS Framework

The EYFS is grounded in four overarching principles:

1. A Unique Child
2. Positive Relationships
3. Enabling Environments
4. Learning and Development

Its aims include ensuring that:

Every child has a safe, healthy, and stimulating start in life

Learning is play-based and developmentally appropriate

Children develop the prime areas (Communication & Language, Physical Development, Personal/Social/Emotional Development) and specific areas (Maths, Literacy, Understanding the World, Expressive Arts & Design)

Equality, anti-discrimination, and inclusion are upheld

Comparative Insights

Both frameworks highlight holistic development, learning through play, and child-centred pedagogy.

The NCDC focuses more on core competencies, local relevance, and community participation.

The EYFS provides clearer, more prescriptive structures and statutory requirements.

EYFS is strongly aligned with safeguarding law, whereas NCDC places more emphasis on community and cultural integration.

3. Learning and Development Requirements.

3.1 Learning Areas

NCDC Learning Areas:

Language development

Numeracy concepts

Environmental exploration

Creative arts (music, drama, drawing)

Social skills, moral values, and life skills

Physical development

Learning areas are approached in a holistic, integrated, competency-based manner.

EYFS Learning Areas:

Prime Areas:

Communication and Language

Physical Development

Personal, Social & Emotional Development

Specific Areas:

Literacy

Mathematics

Understanding the World

Expressive Arts and Design

3.2 Suggested Teaching Methods.

NCDC Methods:

Play-based, activity-based learning
Storytelling, songs, rhymes
Use of locally available materials
Outdoor and indoor exploration
Collaborative learning
Demonstration and guided discovery

EYFS Methods.

Play-based pedagogy supported by intentional teaching
Use of continuous provision zones (construction, role-play, writing, water table)
Adult-led and child-initiated balance
Scaffolding, modelling language, guided interactions
Observations informing planning

3.3 Learning Activities and Play Approaches

NCDC:

Emphasises community-based, culturally relevant play
Use of natural materials (stones, seeds, sticks)
Role-play based on real-life Ugandan contexts
Outdoor play central to daily routine

EYFS:

Play integrated through planned learning centres
Structured free-flow play
Use of modern educational resources (blocks, puzzles, ICT tools)

Comparative Insights:

Both frameworks strongly advocate for play-based learning, but EYFS provides a more defined structure and developmental outcomes.

NCDC prioritises local relevance and improvisation, whereas EYFS leans on standardised educational resources.

EYFS distinguishes clearly between prime and specific areas; NCDC integrates competencies holistically.

4. Assessment Approaches.

NCDC Assessment:

Continuous and observation-based

Competency-focused

Informal and descriptive rather than numerical

Used for guiding teaching rather than ranking

Tools include anecdotal notes, checklists, samples of children's work, and observation reports.

EYFS Assessment:

Ongoing formative assessment through daily observations

Tracking against EYFS Early Learning Goals (ELGs)

Progress Check at Age Two

End-of-Reception assessment (non-exam, observation-based)

EYFS requires detailed documentation and parent involvement.

Comparative Insights:

Both frameworks use continuous observation as the basis of assessment.

EYFS requires formal documentation and statutory reporting; NCDC is less formal and more flexible.

EYFS assessments guide transition to primary curriculum; NCDC aims at readiness for lower primary within a competency pathway.

5. Safeguarding, Welfare, and Safety Requirements

NCDC Requirements:

Hygiene and sanitation standards

Safe indoor/outdoor environment

Teacher accountability and positive discipline

Provision for children with disabilities

Collaboration with parents and community for child protection

Emotional safety through warm, positive interactions

EYFS Requirements:

Child protection policies

Mandatory staff background checks

Staff–child ratios

Health, hygiene, and safety regulations

Fire safety, risk assessments, and first-aid certification

Policies on behaviour management, medication, and supervision

Comparative Insights:

Both emphasise safety and welfare as foundational.

EYFS requirements are more detailed, legally enforceable, and standardised.

NCDC relies more on professional responsibility, community involvement, and contextualised safety measures.

6. Overall Comparative Analysis.

Similarities:

Both frameworks promote holistic development.

Both emphasise play-based, child-centred pedagogy.

Continuous, observation-based assessment is central.

Safeguarding and well-being are prioritised.

Differences:

EYFS has statutory obligations while NCDC provides guiding principles.

EYFS is more structured in learning areas and assessment; NCDC is flexible and contextual.

NCDC strongly promotes cultural relevance and community linkages; EYFS emphasises policy compliance and quality assurance.

EYFS provides clearer guidance on teacher qualifications and ratios; NCDC's guidance is less prescriptive.

7. Application to Vocational Practice.

Pedagogical Practice:

Balance child-initiated and adult-guided learning

Design inclusive, play-rich environments

Use culturally appropriate materials (NCDC influence)

Use structured learning zones (EYFS influence)

Assessment:

Implement continuous, observation-based assessments

Maintain documentation such as learning stories, portfolios

Support children's progress using developmental milestones

Safeguarding Responsibilities:

Ensure a safe, hygienic, and emotionally supportive environment

Apply clear behaviour guidance practices

Work with families and the community for child protection

Professional Conduct:

Reflect on cultural context and its influence on practice

Apply global ECE quality standards while respecting local realities

Advocate for children's holistic well-being and rights